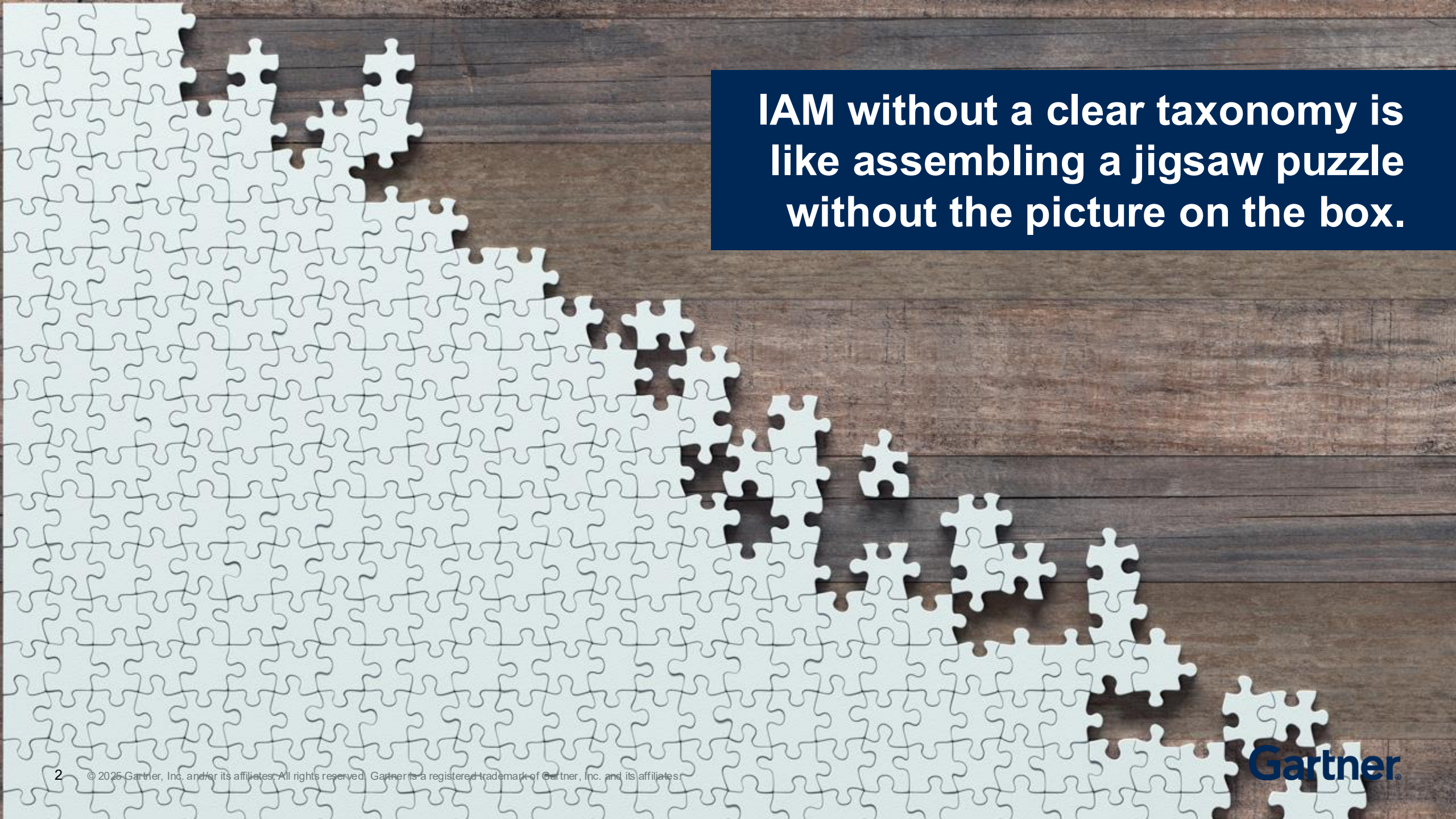


Use an IAM Taxonomy to Evolve Your IAM Program

Erik Wahlström

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**IAM without a clear taxonomy is
like assembling a jigsaw puzzle
without the picture on the box.**



Key Issues

1. Why a taxonomy and why now?
2. The Gartner IAM taxonomy
3. How to use the taxonomy to evolve your IAM program

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6 Reasons Why We Need an IAM Taxonomy Now!



Establishing a common vocabulary



Defining identity and its components



Addressing the blurring distinctions between IAM tools



Understanding nonhuman identities

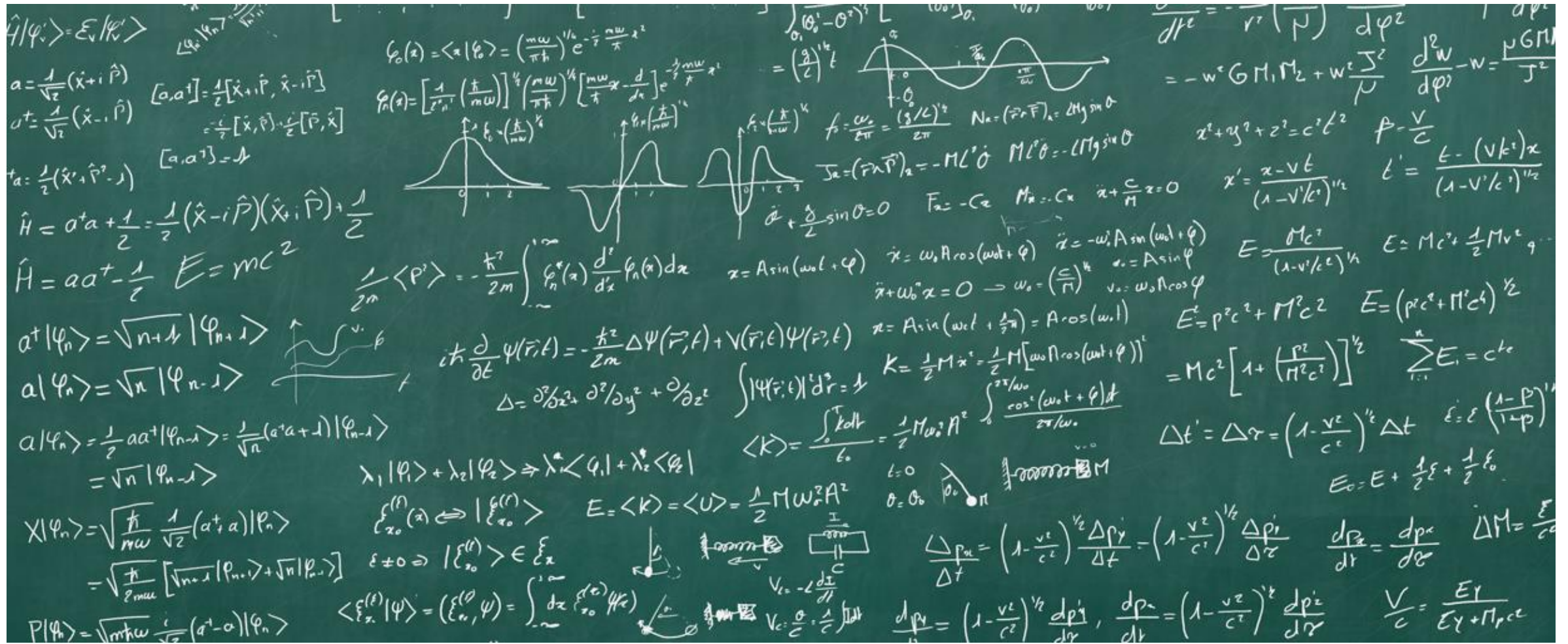


Maximizing existing tooling for effective cost optimization



Demystifying new user constituencies

Making Things as Simple as Possible, While Not Oversimplifying



Key Issue Take-Away:

The establishment and usage of a robust IAM taxonomy is more critical now than ever, as it provides clarity, structure and direction in an increasingly complex identity landscape.

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The Big Picture of IAM



Users

Defined by an IAM taxonomy



Target systems



IAM controls and capabilities



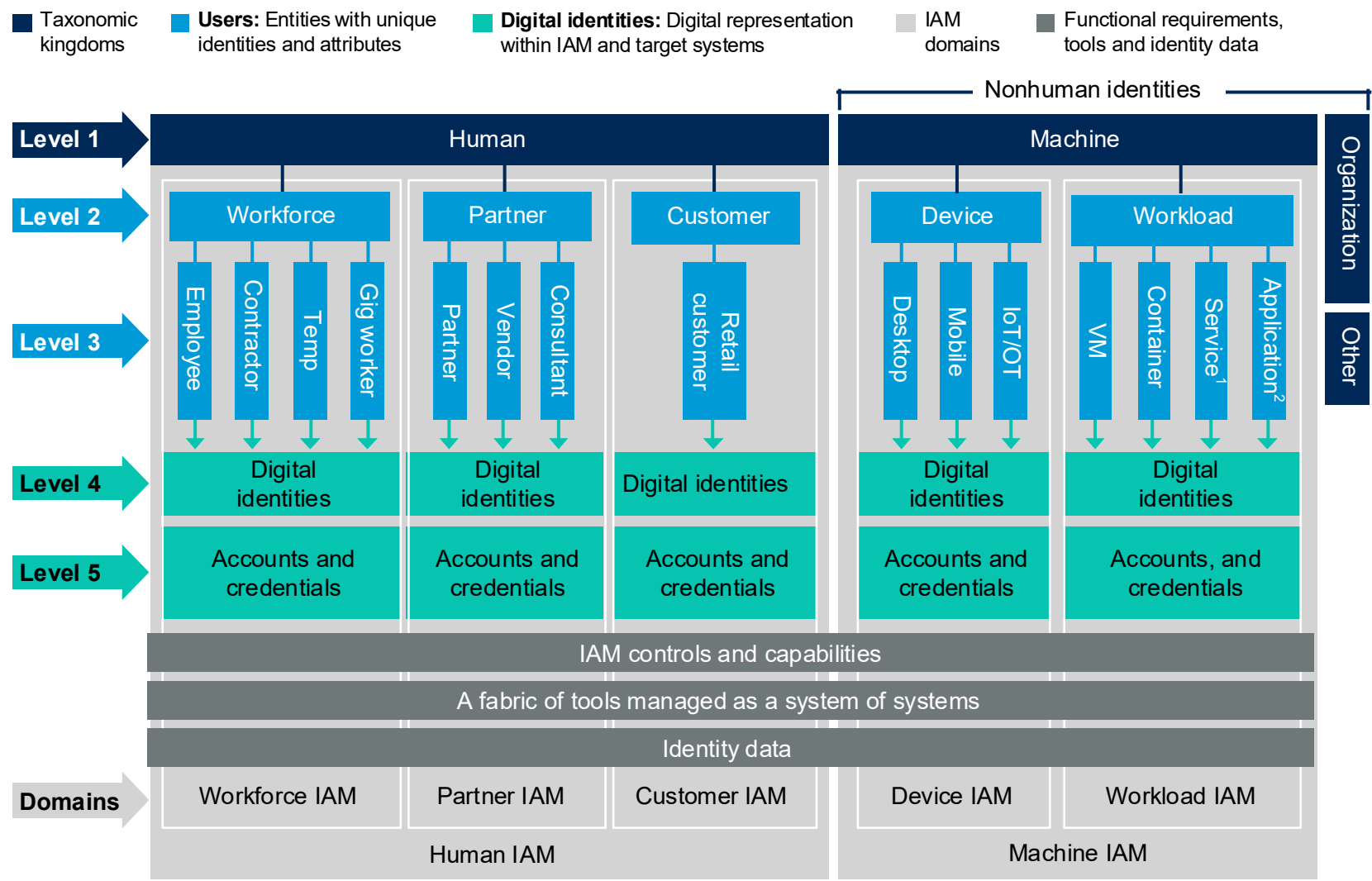
Identity fabric

Operating according to the 10 identity fabric principles



Identity data

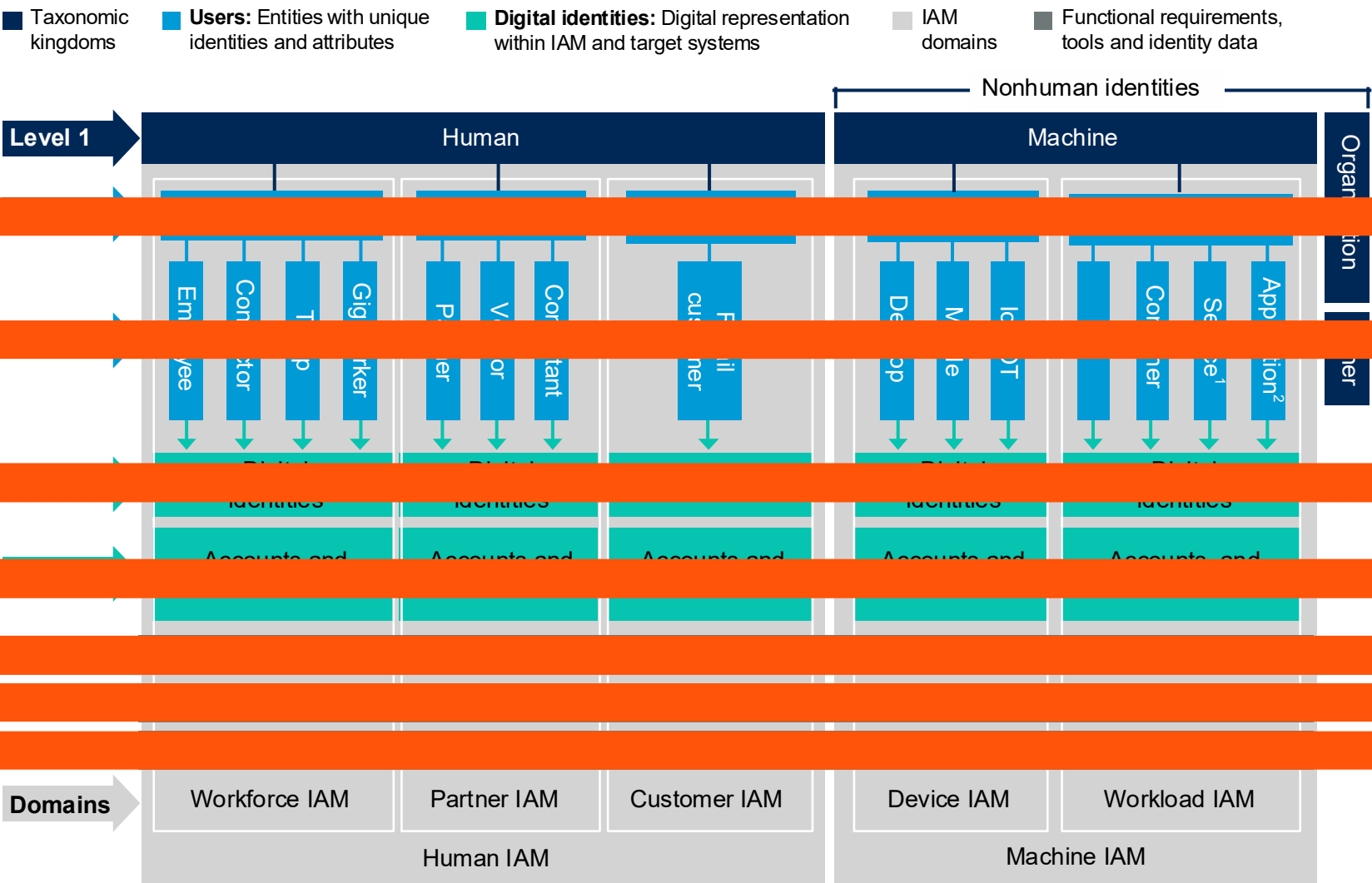
The Gartner IAM Taxonomy



¹ = web, REST, API, RPC, webhook

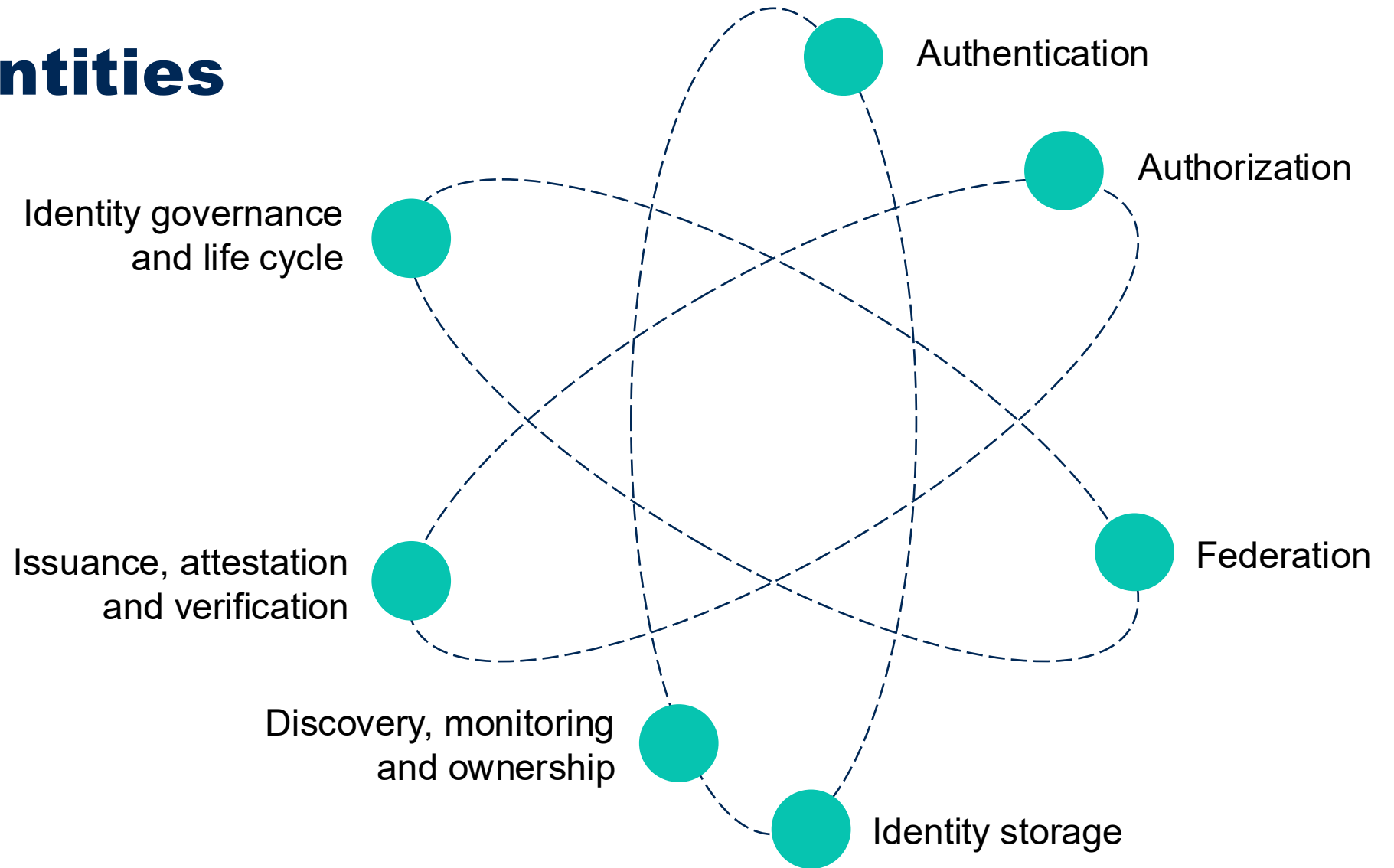
² = web, native, script, service, RPA, AI agent

The Gartner IAM Taxonomy

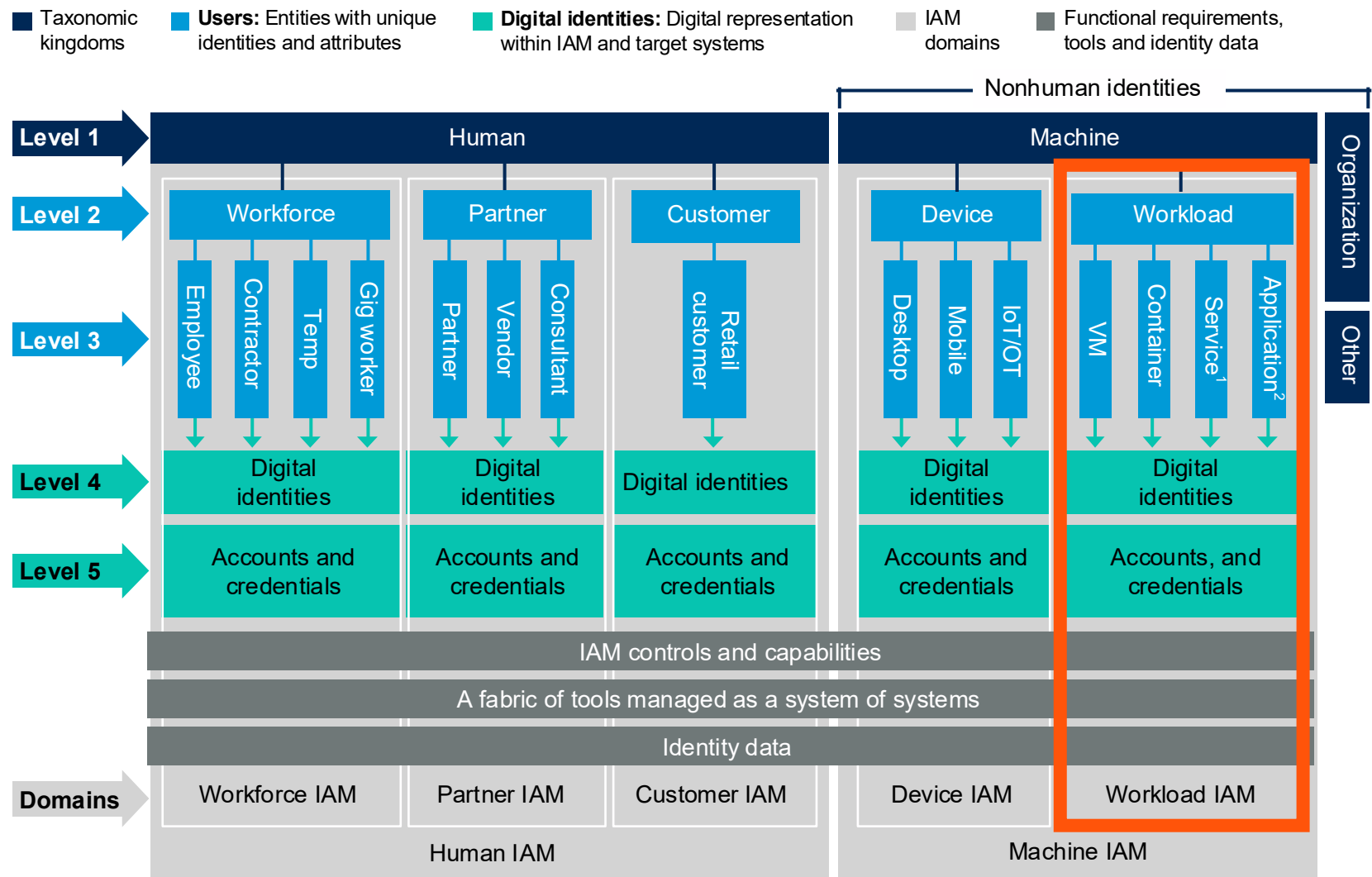


¹ = web, REST, API, RPC, webhook
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Similarities Across All Entities



Domains

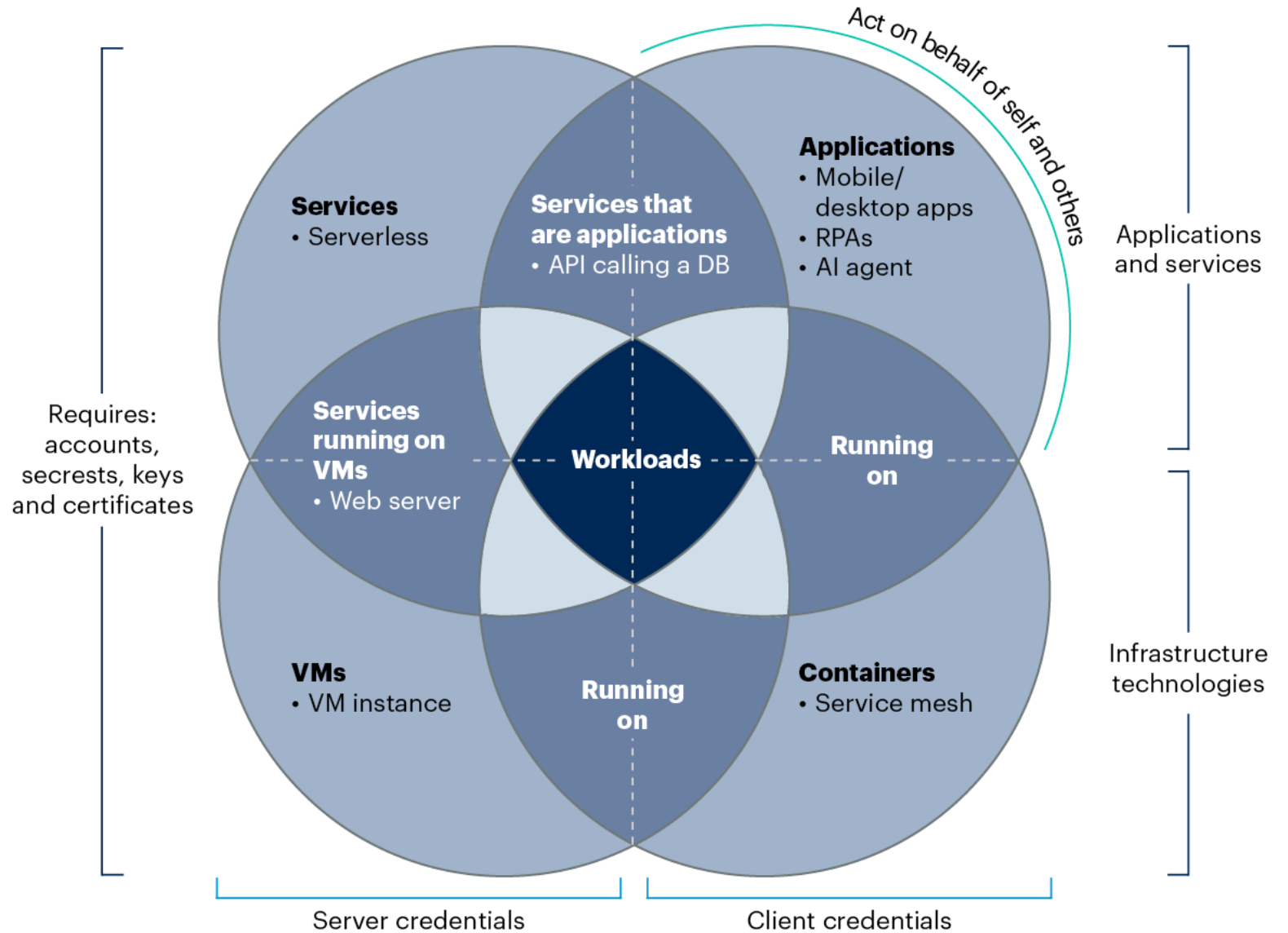


¹ = web, REST, API, RPC, webhook

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Workloads

Applications, services and their relationship to infrastructure

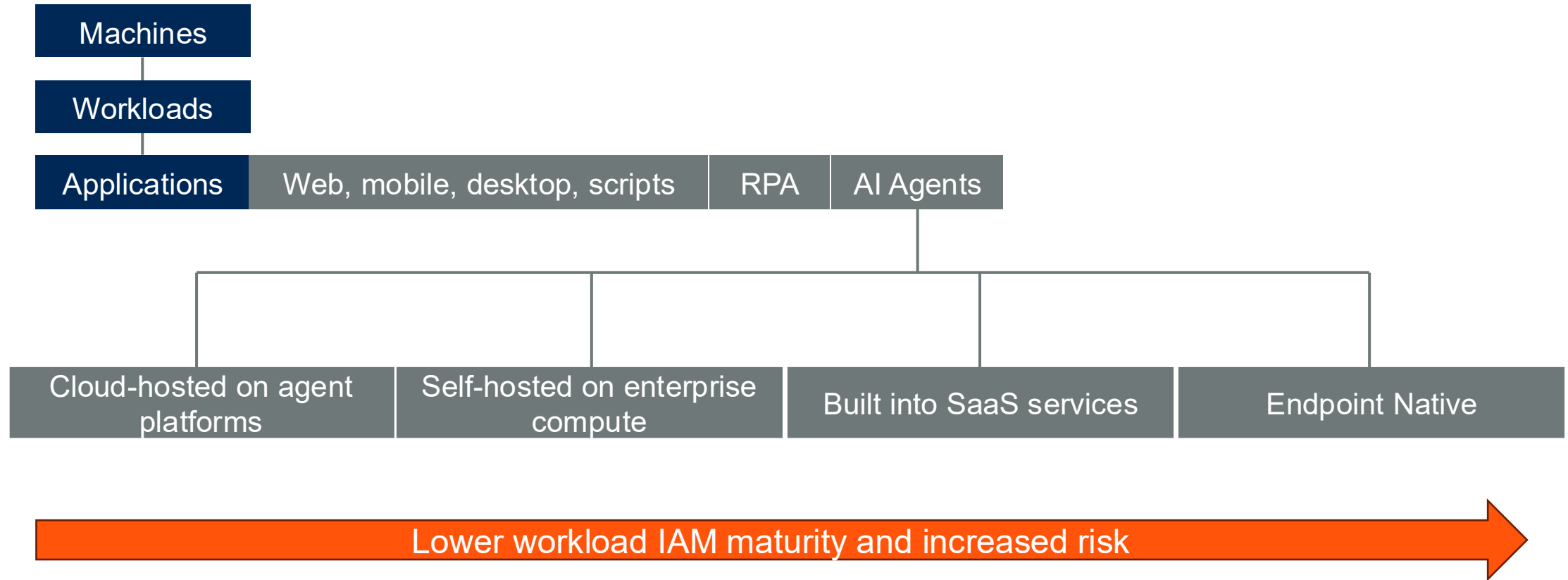


A person wearing a red long-sleeved shirt is sitting in a black office chair, viewed from behind. Their hands are clasped behind their head. They are positioned between two large, illuminated, oval-shaped speakers that are part of a larger system. The background is dark with some light particles, suggesting a high-tech or futuristic environment.

NHI

AI Agents

The Taxonomy of AI Agents



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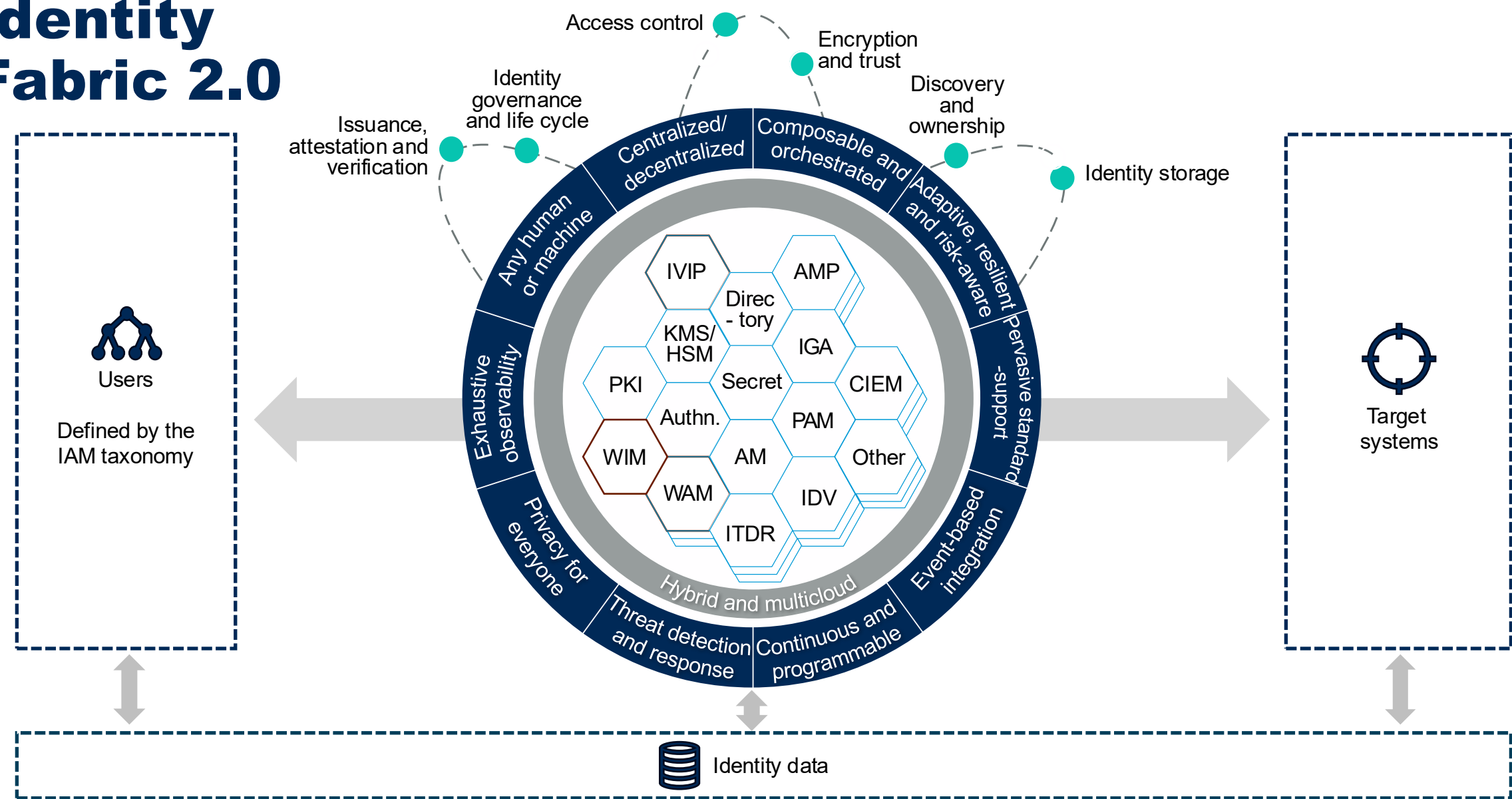
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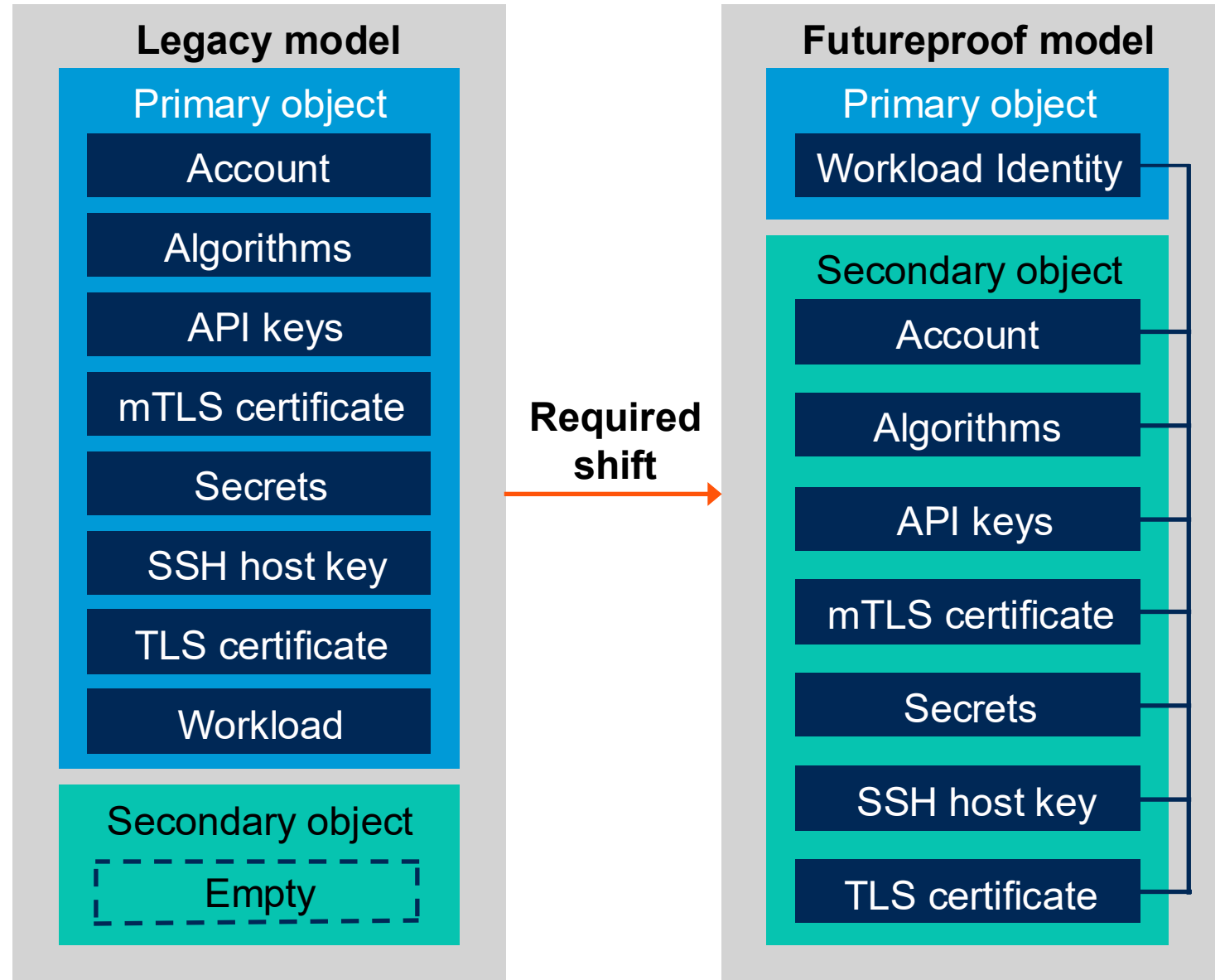


Identity data

Identity Fabric 2.0



Required Adjustments to Legacy Thought Patterns



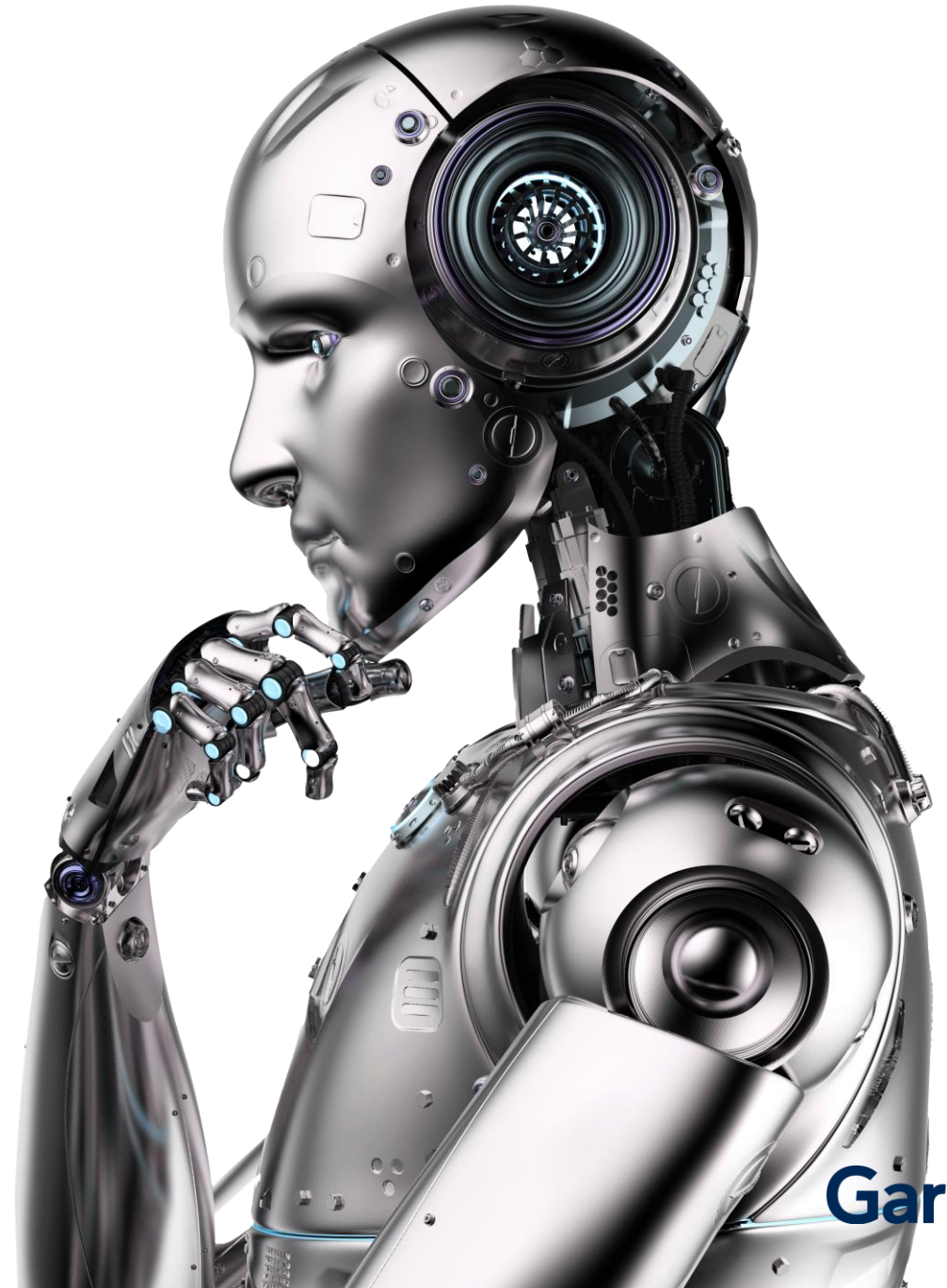
Source: Gartner

Note: API = application programming interface; mTLS = mutual Transport Layer Security; SSH = Secure Shell; TLS = Transport Layer Security

What Is an Identity?

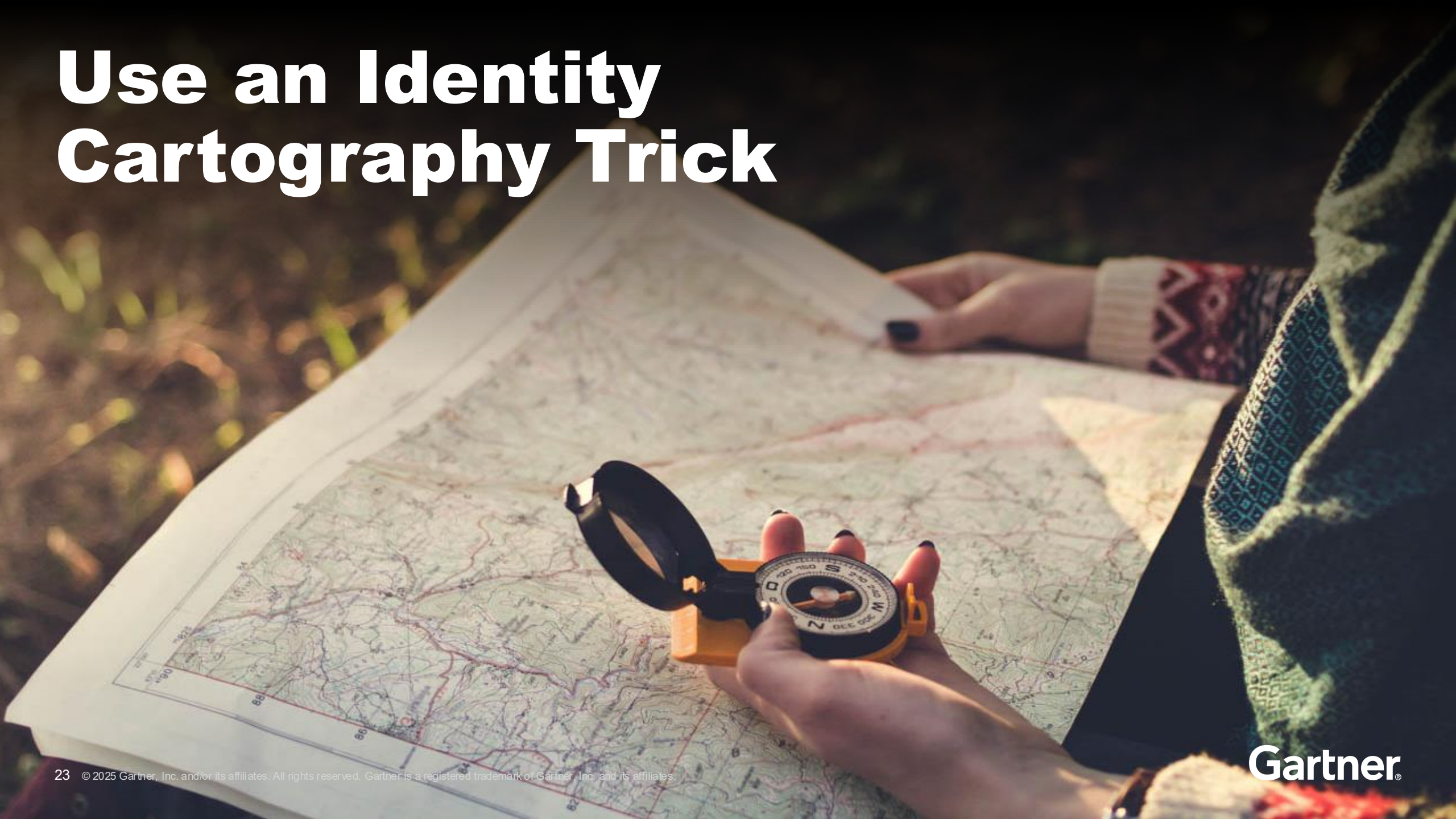
Definition

A digital identity is the digital representation of an entity, which can be human or nonhuman, within digital systems, often associated with accounts and credentials for managing access.



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Use an Identity Cartography Trick

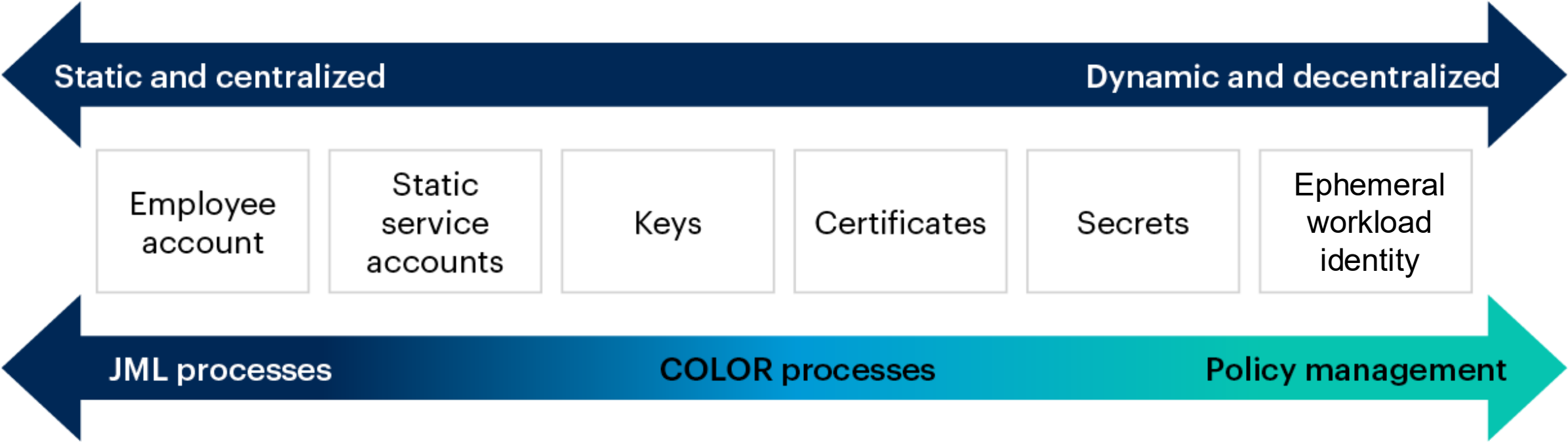


Definitions



**Finding the source
of truth and
establishing trust**

Existing Processes Are Not Helping





COLOR

Creation

Observability

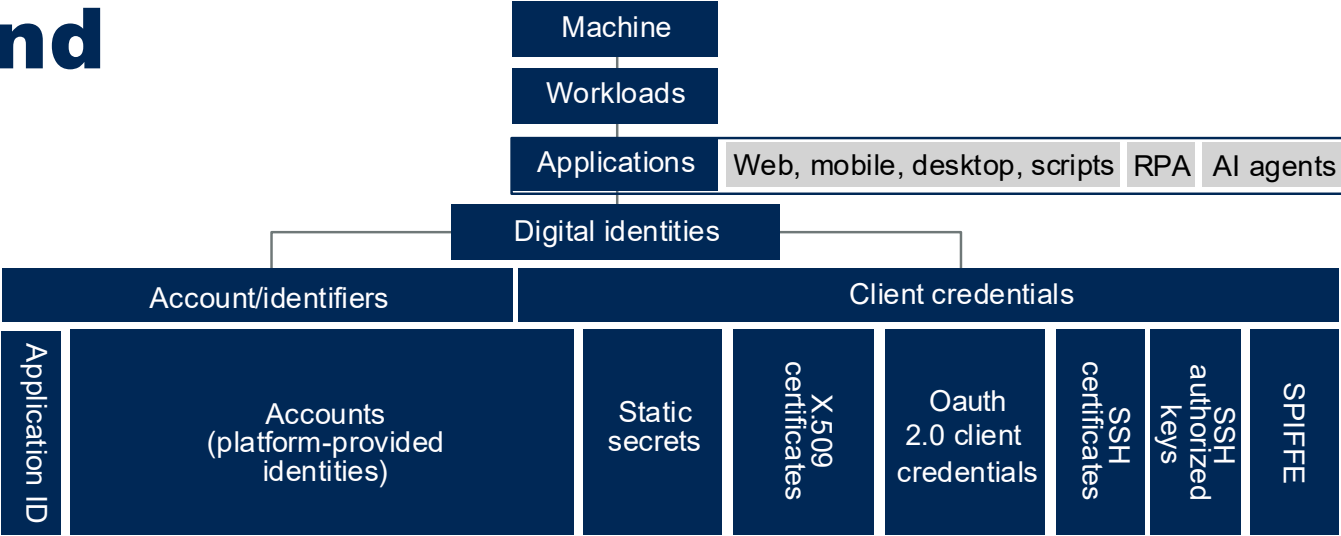
Life cycle management

Ownership

Remediation

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Identify Your Blind Spots at Level 5

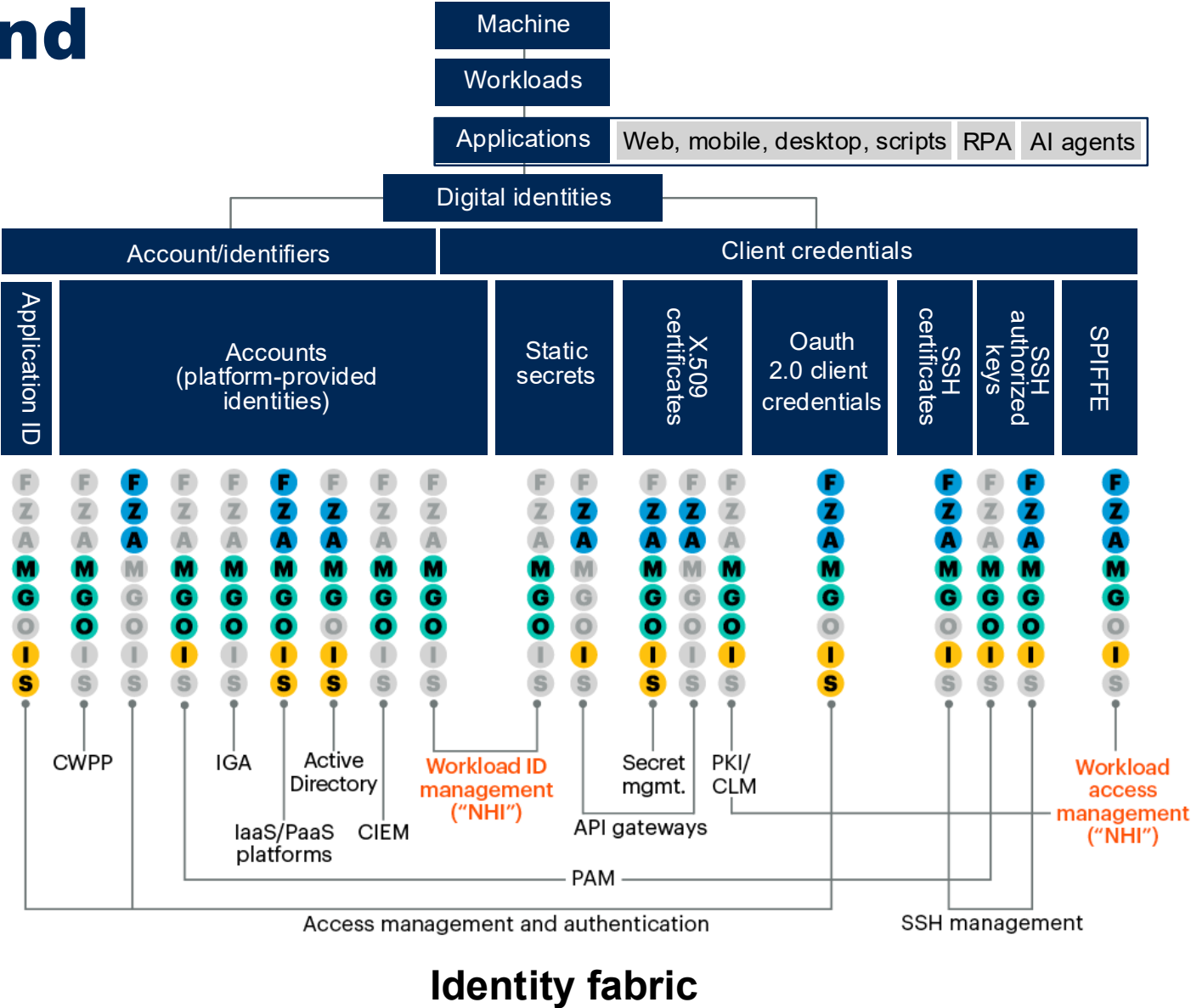


- F** Federation
- Z** Authorization
- A** Authentication
- M** Monitoring and ownership
- G** Identity governance and life cycle
- O** Discovery, monitoring and ownership
- I** Issuance, attestation and verification
- S** Identity storage

Identity fabric

Identify Your Blind Spots at Level 5

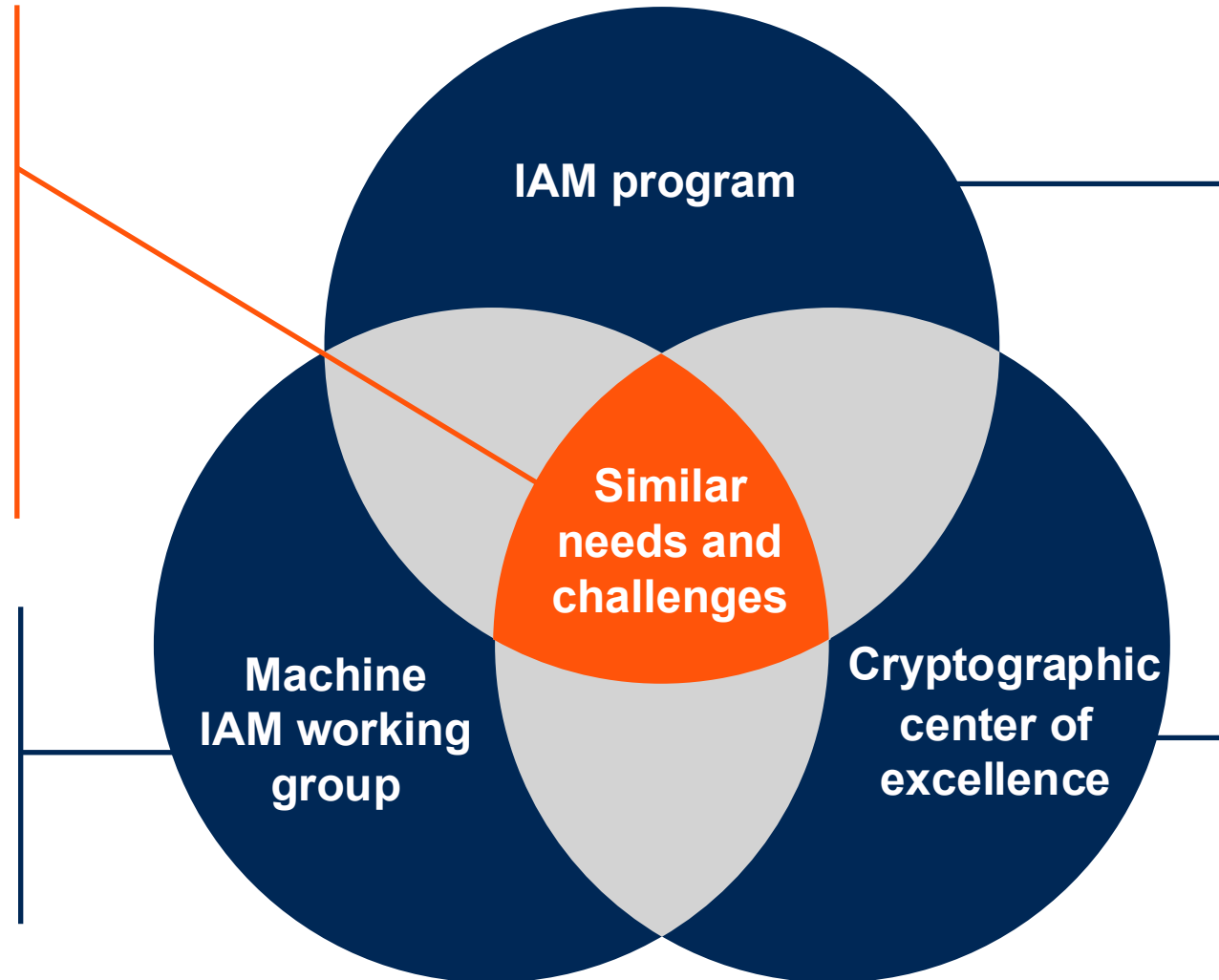
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Teams Sharing Similar Objectives

- Discovery
- Governance
- Monitoring
- Modernization
- Resolve IAM technical debt
- Lacking application management strategies

- Machine IAM
- Service accounts
- Secrets
- Keys
- Certificates



Human IAM

- Workforce IAM
- Partner IAM
- Customer IAM

Machine IAM

- Device IAM
- Workload IAM

- Cryptographic policies
- Keys
- Algorithms
- Certificates

Source: Gartner

Note: IAM = identity and access management

Recommendations

- ④ Use the structured IAM taxonomy to clearly define scope, identify blind spots, understand functional requirements, and set the right expectations within the organization to improve business outcomes.
- ④ Establish distinct strategies for each major IAM domain:
 - Workforce IAM, partner IAM, customer IAM, device IAM and workload IAM.
- ④ Use the taxonomy to demystify new or emerging entities, such as AI agents.
- ④ Treat your IAM environment as a system of systems — an identity fabric — guided by identity fabric principles, acknowledging that no single tool supports the full taxonomy and all IAM domains.
- ④ Make it as simple as possible, but no simpler.

Recommended Gartner Research

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🔍 [IAM — Taxonomy, Domains and Tooling](#)

Erik Wahlstrom

🔍 [2026 Planning Guide for Identity and Access Management](#)

Erik Wahlstrom, Mary Ruddy and Others

🔍 [Evolve IAM Using 10 Identity Fabric Principles](#)

Erik Wahlstrom and Mary Ruddy